

spend their days walking along the beach, hand in hand, or playing golf in the sun.

In our vision of things, there is plenty of room for golf and beach perambulation, but there is no room for retirement. A person should not expect to become a leech on the rest of society just because he reaches a certain age. He should continue to use whatever skills and wisdom are available to him. When those run out completely, then and only then can he become a leech.

The typical lifetime budget of the typical household shows the accumulation of wealth until age 65 . . . and then the wealth declines as it is consumed in retirement. Fair enough. Nothing wrong with that. But in our experience, as limited as it is, both families and retirees gain when old folks, as well as young folks, continue working toward common family goals, including capital formation and preservation. Besides, it isn't as if old people have nothing to contribute.

Youth and energy may be valuable to producing wealth. But old age and cunning are essential to holding onto it. The older a man gets, the more he has seen, including the more scams and absurdities. He is better able to spot them than a younger man. And he is essential to the family's wealth management/protection plan.

Believe it or not, old people are useful in many other ways.

For decades, we lived with three generations in the same house. Never once did we notice that our mother and aunt (or grandmother and great-aunt, depending on which generation you were in) were "retired." They were always busy: fixing meals, looking after the children, cleaning up the house. They were always there, keeping the home fires burning, a plus for the household from every point of view.

Not only were they very helpful in household management, but they were a great source of calm and experience in family matters.

"Inasmuch as you are the oldest and wisest," we would say to our family matriarch, usually after a difficult conversation with a teenager of our own, "what should we do now?"

Our great-aunt died some years ago. But our mother—and grandmother—is still much in demand. She is a stable, wise, and cheerful matriarch at 90 years old. The fact that she is too frail to travel is actually a benefit. She is